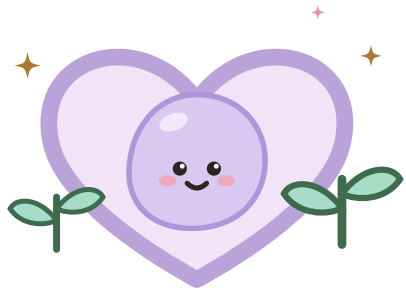
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 2

Heal and Steady

Stress, anger, worry, loss and repair, and finding your footing again



by Christian

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 2: *Heal and Steady*.
By Christian. Published by Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

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Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

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Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-03 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-03: One owner per job”. Every workpaper is free to print or fill in on the website: the book names it and gives a code to scan. *The Workpapers: Free Forms, All in One* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Chat analyzer”. You use it and it gives you something back.

The book keeps the two apart: a workpaper and a tool never share a list. Both are free, need no account, and what you type stays on your device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Part Three, Chapter 12 (online) says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 16, page **60** about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 1 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 2

Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they are flooded, and the kinds of rest that actually help you recover.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Stress is your body getting ready** for a demand. A little helps. Too much, for too long, wears you down.
- **Three everyday states:** calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty. Each one changes how you think and hear.
- **Flooded means offline.** When stress is very high, listening and careful thinking get much harder. Pause, settle, then come back.

- **Rest is a skill.** Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **How much are you carrying? and the stress tank** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) work because stress adds up from many small loads. A full tank makes small things feel big, so you check the tank before you judge the moment. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **The Calm-Down Kit** (Part One, Now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)) settles the body before any words, because a flooded body can't think or listen. Its "come back at a set time" rule stops a pause looking like walking out.
- **The setup score** (Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2)) counts stress as well as hours, because a split that looks fair on paper can still leave one person running on empty.

MONDAY, 7:52AM

The bus is late, the kids can't find a shoe, and your phone buzzes with a work message. Your partner says, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself snap, "I'm not your secretary!" A second later you think, "Where did that come from?" It came from a body that was already full.

The last chapter looked at feelings. This one looks at the system underneath them: your nervous system, and what happens to it under pressure. Understanding stress won't make life less busy. It can make your reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

01

Stress is your body getting ready.

When something needs dealing with, your body gears up: the heart speeds, breathing quickens, muscles tense and stress hormones rise. This is useful. It helps you catch a falling glass, meet a deadline or speak up. The trouble starts when the body stays geared up for too long, with no chance to come back down.

For example: A nurse handles an emergency calmly and well. Two hours later, at home, she can't sit still and cries at an advert. Her body is still running the emergency.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "My body is getting ready for something. That's its job." "The emergency is over. I can let my body catch up."

TRY THIS:
After something stressful, give your body a clear "it's over" signal: a walk, a shower, a stretch or a song.

02

Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same event can be easy for one person and huge for another. Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you have to meet it: time, energy, money, help, skills or sleep. That's why a small thing can tip you over on a bad day, and why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the task at all.

For example: Two coworkers get the same tight deadline. One has a quiet evening ahead. The other has a sick child at home. Same task. Very different stress.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"It's not the task, it's that I don't have much left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

TRY THIS:
When something feels huge, write two lists: what it asks of you, and what you have. Then ask what could make the second list longer.

03

The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture, not a real ladder. In plain words, it means three states your body moves between during the day. This book uses three plain words for them. **Calm and connected:** breathing is easy and you can hear hard things. **Revved up:** fast, tense, and small things feel urgent or personal. **Running on empty:** flat, slow and short of words.

You move up and down all day. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) is a thirty-second self-check. It gives a best guess, not a reading.

For example: A grandfather minding a toddler all afternoon is calm at two, revved up by four and running on empty by six. The same toddler, the same grandfather. The state changed.

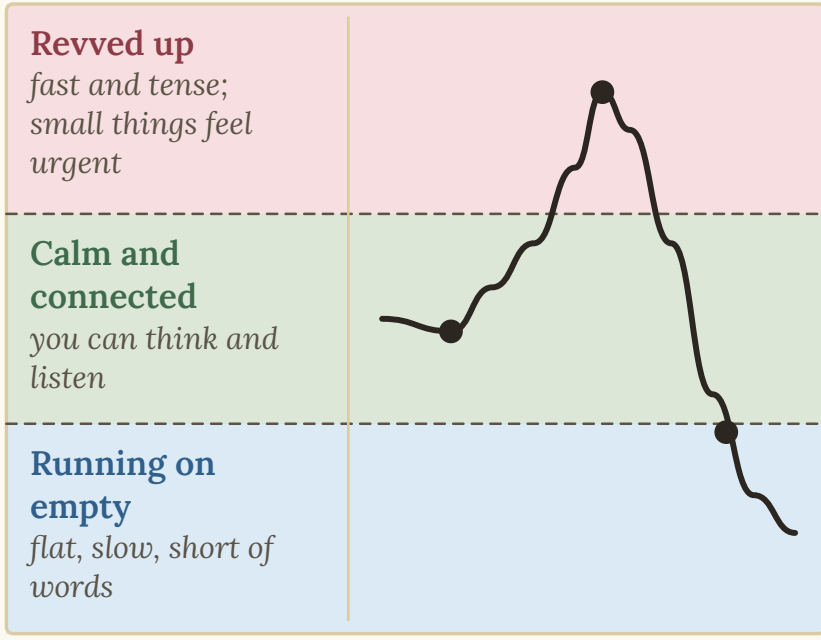
WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I'm revved up right now." "I'm running on empty. Can this wait till morning?"

TRY THIS:

Set three reminders today. Each time, pick a rung: calm, revved up or running on empty. No judging, just noticing.

The ladder: three everyday states

You move up and down it all day.



Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.

Hard talks go best from the middle band.

Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.

FIGURE 1 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day; hard talks go best from the middle band.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The ladder (the sky, in Today's Weather)

Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann

The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · Gusty: Revved up · *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · *Someone I care for* · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · Building · *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · About enough · Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work · Money · *Kids or caring* · *Health* · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · *Rest* · To move · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

Fogged in today
Running on empty · Very little room today

Talk window
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: "I'm at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?"

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.

Fill in your own: Today's Weather: the sky
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks)

04

When you're flooded, thinking goes offline.

At the top of the stress curve, the body is in full alarm. Careful thinking, listening and seeing the other side get much harder. Many people call this being **flooded**. You might say things you don't mean, freeze, or only want to get away. It isn't a character flaw. It's a body that needs to come down before the talk can go on.

For example: Two adult siblings start sorting their late father's things. Within minutes they are shouting about a lamp. Neither cares about the lamp. Both are flooded with grief.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

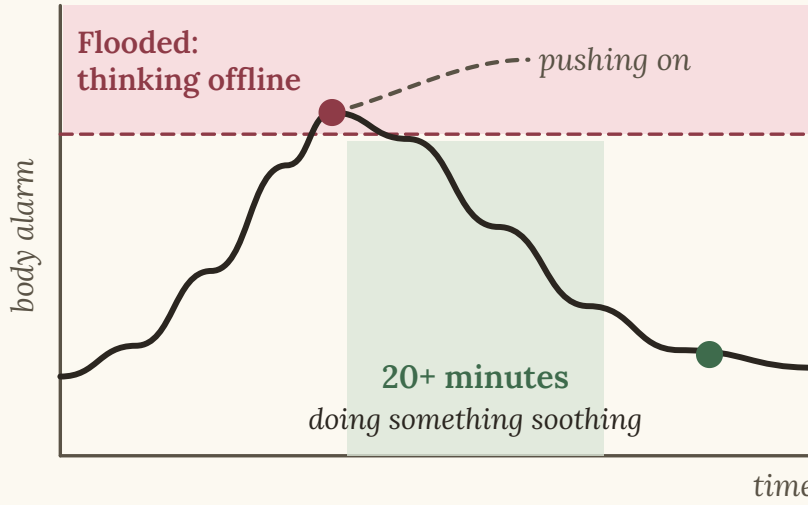
"I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

TRY THIS:

Learn your own flood signs: heat, a racing heart, tunnel vision, a loud inner voice. When you notice two of them, pause.

Flooded means offline

Pause, settle, then come back.



- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.

FIGURE 2 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.

05

Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Think of a tank (in plain words: how much stress you are already carrying today). Stress from one place spills into the next. Traffic, a hard meeting, a noisy shop and a worrying text can all fill the same tank. By evening, a tiny thing makes it overflow. The last drop gets

the blame, but the tank was nearly full already. Small daily hassles count, not just big events.

For example: A teenager explodes when asked to empty the dishwasher. The dishwasher isn't the problem. A friendship fell apart at lunch, and the dishwasher was the last drop.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "My tank was already full when I got home. That wasn't really about you." "Rough day? You don't have to explain."

> TRY THIS:
> Before reacting to a small thing in the evening, ask: "How full was I before this happened?" Part Two's Chapter III has a simple way to tell.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long shower of rain. I would know. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.



WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

06

Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm. You can help the body come down, and the thinking often follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths, moving, cold water on your face, a familiar song, pressure (like a heavy blanket) or simply leaving a noisy room can all help. Different things work for different people.

For example: A manager feels her heart race before giving hard feedback. She walks round the block once, breathing out slowly. She goes in steadier.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Body first, words second." "What has helped me settle before?"

TRY THIS:

On a calm day, list three things that settle you. Keep the list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) helps you build it.

07

Rest isn't one thing.

Lying on the sofa scrolling isn't always rest. Recovery comes in different kinds: sleep, switching off from work in your head, real relaxation, doing something absorbing you enjoy, and feeling in charge of your own time. Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest. Being with people restores some people and drains others.

For example: Housemates plan a "relaxing" Saturday party. One loves it and wakes up refreshed. The other needs all of Sunday alone to recover. Both rested. They just needed different things.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need quiet rest tonight, not people rest. It's not about you." "What kind of tired are you?"

TRY THIS:

Ask yourself: am I body-tired, people-tired, brain-tired or feelings-tired? Pick a rest that matches.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of soft music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it close.

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

08

Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress hit harder. After a short or broken night, small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter and people pull away from each other. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm centre react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), people reported more conflict with their partner after nights of poor sleep. And in experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier. You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it's part of the story.

For example: A nurse coming off three night shifts finds herself in tears over a parking ticket. Her sister says, "You've barely slept. Let's sort it out on Thursday." On Thursday, it's just a parking ticket.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I slept badly. If I'm short with you today, that's why, and it's not about you." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

TRY THIS:

Before a hard conversation, ask: “Have we both slept?” If not, pick another time. At night, try the same few calm steps before bed, in the same order, so your body learns the signal. If poor sleep goes on for weeks, talk to a doctor. Sleep problems are common and often treatable.

09

Stress is easier to carry when it’s shared.

People calm each other. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder or just a quiet person nearby can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud also helps others read you right: “I’m stressed about work” stops a partner or friend from thinking it’s about them. Sharing stress isn’t dumping it. It’s letting someone stand beside you.

For example: A father tells his ten-year-old, “I’m a bit stressed about money this month. It’s my grown-up job to sort it, and you’re not in trouble.” His son stops tiptoeing round him.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“I’m stressed, and it’s not about you.” “Do you want help, a hug, or just some space?”

TRY THIS:

Tonight, tell one person your state in one sentence, and ask theirs.

MONDAY, 7:58AM

Six minutes after the snap, you find your partner by the door. "Sorry. My tank was full before you said a word. Your keys are on the bathroom shelf." They laugh. "Rough start?" "Very." The morning is still busy. It isn't a fight anymore.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** No one notices you're running on empty, so build rest in before you need it. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).
- **With a partner:** Agree a pause word on a calm day, and that whoever pauses names a time to come back. See One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- **With friends:** A friend who cancels again may be overwhelmed, not uninterested. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Parents and children:** A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does. Your calm is borrowed before it is learned.
- **At work:** A flooded colleague can't take in feedback. Waiting an hour often works better than pushing now. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **Shift work, illness and caring:** Some people run on empty for structural reasons. That calls for a different setup, not more effort. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours), When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) and Caregivers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers).

- **If you have ADHD:** Keeping track of everything quietly fills the tank before the day starts. Move the remembering out of your head (a shared list, labelled alarms, one place for keys), and plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"All stress is bad."** Short bursts of stress help you rise to a challenge. The problem is stress with no recovery.
- **"If I'm calm, I can't be upset."** Calm means steady, not happy. You can be calm and sad, or calm and firm.
- **"Pausing is avoiding."** A pause with a time to come back is a way to finish the talk well. A pause with no return is avoiding.
- **"Rest is lazy."** Recovery is part of the work. Bodies and minds that never recover tend to break down.
- **"Everyone should be able to handle what I can."** People have different loads, different bodies and different resources. Compare the load, not the person.
- **"Running on empty means they don't care."** Short replies and flat faces often mean tired, not cold.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Be the calm, not the coach.** A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence help more than "calm down."
- **Lighten the load, not just the mood.** Taking one task off someone's list can do more than any pep talk.

- **Ask what kind of help.** Practical help, company, a distraction or space? Ask, don't guess.
- **Don't debate someone who is flooded.** Offer a break and a time to come back. Facts can wait twenty minutes.
- **Notice long stretches.** If someone has been running on empty for weeks, gently mention it, and help them find support.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

When to get more help

Stress is normal. Constant stress that never lets up is a warning sign. It may be time to see a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional if:

- you've felt exhausted, dread-filled or numb most days for several weeks, even after rest;
- you can't sleep, or sleep but never feel rested;
- you have physical signs that worry you, such as chest pain, constant headaches or stomach trouble (always get chest pain checked straight away);
- you're relying on alcohol, drugs or other habits to get through the day;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that is happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line.

If the stress comes from being afraid of someone, such as how they will react, what they will do or whether you are allowed to leave,

that is not ordinary stress. Your body may be warning you. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not medical advice or diagnosis.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- The Nervous System Ladder: a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer), Brain Breakers (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) and calm games (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play): gentle ways to come down.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), appraisal, the window of tolerance, flooding (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships), burnout and slow breathing (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/calm).

More for your situation

- Back: How feelings work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings) · Next: How we see each other (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-3-seeing) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)
- Part Two, Chapter III: full tanks and different angles

- How to stop fighting: calm steps (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner)
- New baby, sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent) and Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- For teens: big feelings and stress (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Sensory overload at home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Stress is your body getting ready** for a demand. A little helps. Too much, for too long, wears you down.
- ✓ **Three everyday states:** calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty. Each one changes how you think and hear.
- ✓ **Flooded means offline.** When stress is very high, listening and careful thinking get much harder. Pause, settle, then come back.
- ✓ **Rest is a skill.** Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank in a shared home
Share the Load

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words
Your weather before you speak
Know Yourself Kindly

Book 3 · Why we get out of tune
How stress knocks two people out of tune
Understanding Each Other

Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When stress turns into worry or low mood
page 45

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

The Nervous System Ladder
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth

2

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 2 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 13

Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterwards, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed. What you do with it is the part you choose.
- **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it. Calming the body, then putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments, helps more.

- **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The Calm-Down Kit** (Part One, Now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)) works because anger rises in the body first. Slowing the body is what makes the words possible. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **"Let a comment land before you react" and "Notice, name, decide"** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) are the step back this chapter describes: look from the outside, then choose.

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

Your brother texts: "Can't take Mum to the hospital on Thursday after all. Sorry!!" It's the third time this month. Your jaw sets and your thumbs start typing fast: "TYPICAL. You never..." Your heart is pounding, your face is hot, and the message is nearly sent.

Many of us were taught anger was rude or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. But anger itself is a normal human feeling, and it often points at something real. This chapter explains how anger works first, and what to do with it second.

01

Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says "That's not fair," "You're in my way" or "Someone crossed a line." It pushes us *towards* a problem, to change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or be far bigger than the problem.

For example: A woman keeps finding her lunch gone from the office fridge. Her anger tells her a line has been crossed, and gets her to raise it.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "What is this anger trying to protect?" "Is this about fairness, a blocked plan, or feeling unsafe?"

> TRY THIS:
> Next time you feel angry, finish this sentence privately: "I'm angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___."

02

Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than what sits under it: hurt, fear, shame, worry or plain tiredness. In Chapter 1 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings) we called this layers. Finding the layer underneath often shows what you actually need.

For example: A man snaps at his teenage daughter for coming home an hour late. Under the anger is a cold hour of fear: "What if something happened?" When he says that part, she hears it, and apologises.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm angry, and I think underneath I was really scared." "I came across cross. I think I'm actually hurt."

TRY THIS:

After the next angry moment, when you're calm, ask: "Was there hurt, fear or tiredness under it?"

03

Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart, a louder voice, fists or shoulders tensing. This is the body getting ready for a fight, and it can happen in seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking and listening get much harder. Chapter 2 (page 7) calls this being flooded: so stirred up that the thinking part of you goes quiet for a while.

For example: Arguing about the bins, a woman notices her hands shaking and realises she can't hear a word her housemate says. That's her sign to stop.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"My body is ready for a fight. That doesn't mean I have to have one." "Where is this in my body?"

TRY THIS:

Learn your own early signs. Write down two or three, like "jaw tight" or "talking faster." They are your cue to slow down.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.



WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

04

In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Simple steps help: stop talking or typing, breathe out slowly (longer out than in), unclench your hands, and if you can, move away for a while. A large review of 154 studies by Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

For example: A dad feels his temper rising while helping with homework. He says, "I'm getting frustrated, and that's not your fault. I'm going to get a glass of water and come back in five minutes." He does. The homework gets done.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

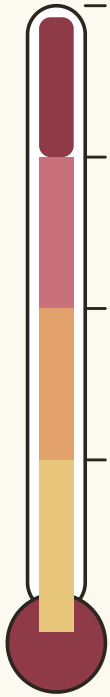
"I'm too angry to talk well right now. I'll come back at eight." "I need ten minutes. I'm not leaving the conversation, I'm coming back to it."

TRY THIS:

Make a three-step plan on a calm day: your early sign, the words you'll say, and where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) has steps for the hottest moments.

Anger rises fast

What helps depends on how hot it is.



Hot minutes
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

Angry
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

Annoyed
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

Irritated
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.
Then repair any sharp moments.

In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help. If anger frightens or controls someone, safety comes first.

FIGURE 3 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first; letting rip feeds it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

The Calm-Down Kit
Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13

The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
Pat (Nan)

Date
4 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
Door slammed after a call with his mum	*Shoulders up by my ears*
Being shouted at in front of the neighbours	*Hot face, can't find words*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Gating (lower the lights, step out)

Second, if the first isn't available
Low, steady sound

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm putting the kettle on for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you at half past.

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
"Kettle time"

The shortest break we take
20 minutes

How we set the time to come back
Whoever pauses says a time before they go

The first sentence when we come back
"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
5:10 pm	*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up
After tea, at 6

☑ I'm going with this

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating", one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11)

05

Letting rip doesn't empty it.

Many people believe anger is like steam: let it out, by shouting, slamming or hitting a pillow, and it will be gone. Research doesn't support this. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier, not calmer.

So does going over and over what happened in your head: in studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even towards someone

who only mildly annoyed them. Anger tends to fade faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

For example: After a row with a coworker, a man spends his lunch telling three people how awful she is. By the afternoon he's angrier than ever. Next time, he takes a walk instead, and by two o'clock he can think clearly.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "Going over this again is feeding it." "I can come back to this later, when I'm calmer."

> TRY THIS:
> If you notice yourself replaying an argument, set a timer for twenty minutes and do something absorbing. Come back to the problem after.

06

Step back and look from the outside.

Once the body has settled a little, it helps to look at the moment as if you were watching from across the room. What happened? What might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall," rather than reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

For example: Furious that a friend cancelled again, a woman imagines telling the story to a kind stranger. Told that way, she remembers her friend is caring for a sick parent. The anger softens into worry.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"If I were watching this from the side, what would I see?"
"What else might be going on for them?"

TRY THIS:

Write two lines about the moment, starting with your own name instead of "I": "Wes got angry because..."

07

Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. When you are calmer, you can still say you were angry, and why, without attacking. A simple shape helps: what happened (the facts), how you felt, and what you're asking for.

For example: Instead of "You always let me down," a woman says to her sister: "When you cancelled Mum's appointment again, I felt really angry and alone with it. Can we make a plan for who takes her, for the next three months?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?" "When ___ happened, I felt ___. What I'm asking for is ___."

TRY THIS:

Write your angry message, then rewrite it in the three-part shape before you send anything. See Chapter 4 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-4-communication) for more on saying hard things.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

08

After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp sometimes. What matters a great deal is what happens next. A short, real repair (naming what you did, without "but," and saying what you'll do differently) helps rebuild trust.

For example: A grandmother shouts at her grandson for breaking a vase, and he cries. An hour later she sits with him: "I shouted, and that was scary. The vase isn't as important as you. I'm sorry." He hugs her.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry."
"I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

TRY THIS:

Think of one recent moment when your anger landed on someone. Is there a short repair you could still make? Chapter 11 (page 83) has more on apologies that land.

09

When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening,

shouting so someone is scared, or using anger to control what another person does, wears, spends or who they see. People walking on eggshells around you is a sign too. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

For example: A man realises his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they are afraid of him. He talks to his doctor and joins an anger course.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it." (If it's happening to you) "I'm frightened of how they get when they're angry."

TRY THIS:

If this sounds like you, see help with your own anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents). If you're afraid of someone else's anger, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down, and you don't have to accept being shouted at, threatened or controlled. If someone else's anger frightens you, getting safe matters more than working it out. Not safe at home?

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

You put the phone face down and walk round the block. Breathing out long, you notice what's under the anger: you're tired, and you're scared about Mum. Back home you send a different message: "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel alone with Mum's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"

Your brother rings within ten minutes. His shifts have changed and he's been too embarrassed to say. You make a plan together. The anger was right that something needed to change. It just needed words instead of capitals.

If you're a teenager

A *made-up example.* Maisie, 16, has her phone taken at ten, mid-chat with her friends. She shouts and slams the door. The next morning, calmer, she says: "It felt like you didn't trust me. Sorry for the door. Could I have ten minutes' warning?" Her dad says yes.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and arguments often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care isn't control, even when it feels unfair. A calm ask the next day works more often than a slammed door.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "It's not the rule I mind, it's how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Anger at yourself counts too. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward. Speak to yourself as you would to a friend who made the same mistake. See Chapter 7 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth).
- **With a partner:** Agree on a pause word on a calm day, and a time you'll always come back. See When we keep having the same fight (spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner).
- **Parents and children:** Children copy what we do with anger more than what we say about it. See For parents.
- **With family and friends:** Old anger can flare at gatherings. Plan a short break. See Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).
- **At work:** Anger at work is common and rarely said. "I'm frustrated about the deadline change. Can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **If you have ADHD:** Anger can arrive fast and big, then pass quickly. Plan for the speed: a three-word pause line ("Back in ten"), and a rule to wait before you send anything. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth).
- **Managing a clash between two people:** Hear each person alone first, then together, about what happened, not about each other. Often the fight is about the setup, like two people who both think they own the same job. A worked example.

Common mix-ups

- **"Anger is a bad feeling."** Anger is a normal feeling. Some things done in anger are harmful. The feeling itself is information.
- **"Letting it out is healthy."** Shouting or hitting things tends to keep anger going. Calming the body and then talking helps more.
- **"They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted."** Someone can do something unfair. What you do next is still yours.
- **"Holding it in is the safe option."** Swallowing anger for years tends to come out sideways: as coldness, sarcasm or a sudden explosion. Saying it calmly and early is safer.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Keep yourself safe first.** If someone's anger scares you, step away. You don't have to stay and calm them down.
- **Lower, slower, fewer words.** Speak quietly and simply. Don't argue the point while they are flooded.
- **Take the message, not the blow.** Often there's something fair under the anger. You can hear that part and still say the way it was said wasn't okay.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" "I can tell this really matters to you."

When to get more help

Everyone gets angry. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or an anger management course if:

- your anger feels out of control, or you often regret what you do or say when angry;
- people close to you seem nervous or walk on eggshells around you;
- you have hit, pushed, thrown things, broken things or threatened anyone;
- anger is hurting your work, your friendships or your health;
- you are using alcohol or drugs to cope with angry feelings.

Help for anger works for many people: a review of anger treatments by Del Vecchio and O'Leary (2004) found medium to large benefits. It is good for your health too: a review by Chida and Steptoe (2009) linked anger and hostility with a higher risk of heart disease. Asking for help is a responsible thing to do. Help with your own anger has first steps.

If you are afraid of someone else's anger, that fear is an important signal. Not safe at home? lists free, private help. If you or anyone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers pages you fill in, on your own or together

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- When we keep having the same fight and When one talks and one goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw).
- How to apologise so it counts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages).
- The library: anger (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), going over and over things, rethinking versus holding it in, time-outs (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict) and managing flooding.

More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
- For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- Family rifts · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work
- Not safe at home?
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed. What you do with it is the part you choose.
- ✓ **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- ✓ **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it. Calming the body, then putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments, helps more.
- ✓ **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4 · Full tanks and different angles — Share the Load
Leftover stress behind a reaction

Book 1 · How feelings work — Know Yourself Kindly
Feelings as signals

Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt — page 83
Repair after the hot minutes

Book 1 · Who you are becoming — Know Yourself Kindly
A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth

3

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 3 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 16

Worry, low mood and trauma

How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, how to support someone, and when and where to get more help. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2 (page 7). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.

- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **The daily check-in's "low, medium or high"** (Part Two, Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1)) works because worry and low mood shrink the room you have. Saying so lets the people around you adjust. Big idea: *read your state first.*
- **"A full tank means later, not never"** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going, and a named time doesn't.
- **Pick one small goal** (Part One, Next (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next)) fits low mood: doing often comes before feeling better.

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

The house is quiet. You've checked the front door twice. Tomorrow is the hospital appointment, and the same three thoughts go round: what if it's bad, what if I can't cope, what if there's nobody to tell. Your chest is tight and your mind won't stop. You haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks either. Everything feels like too much effort.

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people these feelings settle by themselves. For others they stick, grow and start to shape every day. This chapter explains how they work, what tends to help, and when it's time to ask for more help. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you are not alone, and things can get better.

01

Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that is here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen. Worry is the thinking part: "What if…?" on repeat. They use the same stress system as Chapter 2 (page 7): a racing heart, tight chest, shallow breathing, a churning stomach, poor sleep. The alarm is trying to protect you. The trouble is that it can be set too sensitive, and it can't tell a real tiger from a worrying email.

For example: A teenager's heart pounds before every class presentation. Nothing bad has ever happened. Her alarm still treats a room of classmates like danger.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"This is my alarm, not a fact." "My body is getting ready to protect me. I can thank it and carry on."

TRY THIS:

When worry rises, breathe out slowly, longer out than in, five times. Then name three things you can see. It tells the body the danger isn't here right now.

02

Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief. But the relief teaches the brain, "Good thing we escaped." Next time, the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is the opposite: going back towards the feared thing in small, chosen steps, and staying long enough to learn that you can cope. Therapists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

For example: After a panic attack on a bus, a man starts walking everywhere. With his sister's help he takes one stop, then two, then a whole journey. The fear fades as his brain learns buses are survivable.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

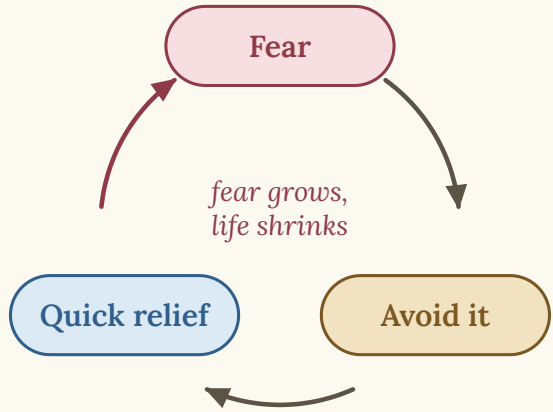
"What do I think will happen? Let's see what actually happens."
"Uncomfortable isn't the same as dangerous."

TRY THIS:

Pick one small thing you've been avoiding. Break it into three steps, from easiest to hardest. Do the easiest one this week.

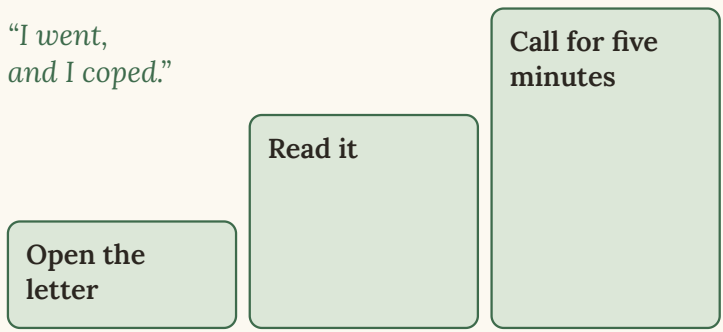
Avoiding keeps fear going

Quick relief now, a smaller life later.



The way back: small, planned steps

*"I went,
and I coped."*



Planned, gradual approach (exposure) is among the most effective treatments for anxiety; it builds new learning that competes with the old fear (Craske and colleagues, 2014). A therapist can help with strong fears.

FIGURE 4 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most, and a therapist can help with strong fears.

03

Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps many people is postponing it: noticing a worry, writing it down, and saving it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practised this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, sort each worry: is there something I can do? If yes, plan one step. If not, practise letting it go.

For example: A father caring for his own dad keeps a worry notebook by the kettle. At 6pm he gives it fifteen minutes. Many of the morning's worries already look smaller.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Noted. I'll think about that at six." "Can I do anything about this today? If not, it can wait."

TRY THIS:

Choose a fifteen-minute worry time, not just before bed. Keep a note on your phone for worries that pop up in between.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Flip it

Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam

Flip it

What's on your mind?

What if I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone | A *worry* | Being hard on myself | Anger

THE FLIP

The best outcome would be
[what you hope for]

The main thing in the way
I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

If that happens, I'll
[one small thing you could do]

One step today
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version
Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.

When the worry comes back at 1am
It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust, or your doctor.

Fill in your own: Flip it (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a disappointment is normal. Depression is different: low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, changes in appetite, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard

to think. It can look like sadness, or like irritability, numbness or just running on empty. It is a health problem, not a character flaw.

For example: A retired teacher notices he has stopped going to his walking group, isn't reading, and wakes at four every morning. He tells himself he's just old. His daughter gently suggests it might be depression, and that it's treatable.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness." "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

> TRY THIS:
> If you've felt low or lost interest most days for two weeks or more, book a talk with a doctor this week. Write down what you've noticed to take with you.

05

Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood says, "Wait until you feel like it." But withdrawing makes life emptier, which deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioural activation turns this round: plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure, meaning or achievement, and do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

For example: A woman living alone after her divorce plans three small things a day: a ten-minute walk, one call or message, one task she can finish. Some days they feel pointless. Over a few weeks, the days start to feel less flat.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"I don't have to feel like it to do it." "Small counts."

TRY THIS:

Write down three tiny things for tomorrow: one for pleasure, one for connection, one you can finish. Tick them off, however small.

06

Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter, but the evidence for them is solid. Improving sleep can lift mood: in a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too: a review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. And belonging to groups protects: Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse.

For example: A new dad, exhausted and flat, agrees with his partner on one protected long sleep each weekend each, a pram walk every morning, and a weekly game of five-a-side.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."

TRY THIS:

Pick the one basic that is most off for you right now, sleep, moving or people, and make one small change to it this week.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common: in surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

For example: Months after a car crash, a woman still jumps at screeching brakes and avoids driving at night. She isn't "overreacting." Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger, and hasn't unlearned it yet.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"My reactions make sense after what happened." "It's in the past, even if my body doesn't feel that yet."

TRY THIS:

If something frightening happened more than a month ago and it still shapes your days, talk to a doctor. Trauma-focused talking therapies help many people.

08

After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. In fact, a review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first. The same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

For example: After a break-in, a grandmother doesn't want to talk about it. Her grandson doesn't push. He fixes the lock, stays the night, and says, "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here." A week later, she does.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "You don't have to tell me anything. What would help right now?" "You're safe now. I'm staying."

> TRY THIS:
> If someone you love has been through something frightening, ask one practical question ("What do you need today?") and one open one ("How are you doing, really?"), and let them choose.

09

Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It is one of the most studied talking therapies: a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest

support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioural activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Questions about medicine, including starting, changing or stopping it, are for a doctor or prescriber. Please don't stop a medicine suddenly without advice.

For example: A young man is embarrassed to ask for help with panic attacks. His GP refers him to a short course of CBT. Eight sessions later, he's back on the train to work.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while."
"What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

TRY THIS:

Write three lines before an appointment: what you've noticed, how long, and what it's stopping you doing. It makes the first conversation easier.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back towards life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work, not a failure at it. If you feel unsafe, reaching out today matters more than anything in this book.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope and told them: tomorrow. You slept, a bit. This morning you breathe out long at the kitchen window, then text your neighbour: "Hospital at ten. A bit scared. Fancy a cuppa after?"

She replies with three hearts and "Of course." The appointment is still the appointment. But you're not facing it alone, and you've noticed something: it's been weeks of feeling flat. You add a line to the envelope: "Ask the doctor about my mood too."

If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all pile up, often at 1am. A *made-up example*: Tolu, 17, can't sleep before a chemistry exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step, and puts her phone in another room. The next day she tells her mum, and it helps more than she expected.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping, eating or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust or your doctor. Under 19 in the UK, you can call Childline free on 0800 1111.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Living alone can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss. A daily small contact, a call, a message, a walk with someone, protects you. See On your own: when it's lonely (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).
- **With a partner:** Low mood can look like not caring; anxiety can look like nagging. Name it: "I'm low, not cross with you." See Chapter 2 (page 7) on stress in two people.
- **Parents and children:** Children and teens get anxious and low too. Calm, routine and listening help more than reassurance on repeat. See For parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents) and For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).
- **With friends and family:** A friend who keeps cancelling may be struggling, not drifting. Keep inviting, with no pressure. See When a friend goes quiet (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **After a loss:** Grief and depression overlap but aren't the same. See Chapter 8 (page 65) and Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief).
- **At work:** Stress, worry and low mood are common at work and rarely spoken about. A short, honest line to a manager often opens up support. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).
- **If you have ADHD:** Avoidance often looks like putting things off. Make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer, or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth).

Common mix-ups

- **"Anxiety means something is wrong with me."** Anxiety is a normal alarm. It becomes a problem when it's too loud, too often, or starts shrinking your life.
- **"Depression is just sadness. Snap out of it."** Depression affects sleep, energy, thinking and body as well as mood. Nobody snaps out of it, but many people recover with the right help.
- **"Everything bad that happens is trauma."** Trauma usually means threat to life or safety. Other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair.
- **"Talking about trauma straight away helps everyone."** Some people want to talk, some don't. Forcing it can make things worse. Safety and choice come first.
- **"Asking someone about suicide puts the idea in their head."** It doesn't. A review by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found no evidence that asking increases suicidal thoughts, and it may help.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Notice and ask.** "You've seemed low lately. How are you doing, really?" Then listen more than you talk.
- **Don't argue with the feeling.** "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away. "That sounds really hard" keeps them close.
- **Offer something specific.** A walk, a meal, a lift to the doctor, sitting together. Small and practical beats big and vague.

- **Ask directly about safety if you're worried.** "Are you having thoughts of ending your life?" If yes, stay with them, and get help together today.
- **Look after yourself too.** Supporting someone who is struggling is tiring. See Chapter 12 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here."
> "Would it help if I came with you to the doctor?"

When to get more help

Talk to a doctor, a counsellor or a mental health service if:

- you've felt low, empty or hopeless, or lost interest in things, most days for two weeks or more;
- worry or panic is stopping you doing things, or you're avoiding more and more;
- something frightening happened over a month ago and still shapes your days and nights;
- you're using alcohol, drugs, food or anything else to cope;
- you're not sleeping, eating or looking after yourself;
- you have thoughts of harming yourself.

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or you are in danger, get help now. Call your local emergency number (911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 in most of Europe). In the US, call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, or text HOME to 741741. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123, or text SHOUT to 85258.

In Canada, call or text 988. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Under 19 in the UK? Childline is free on 0800 1111. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines in your country. More are on Someone to talk to, free (spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help).

In England you can usually refer yourself to NHS Talking Therapies without seeing a GP first. Find a counsellor or therapist has more places to start. If someone at home is hurting or frightening you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education. It isn't a diagnosis or a substitute for care from a professional.

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11): a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now): steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- Today's Weather (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks): a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

Reading **pages to read on the website**

- The calm visualizer (spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer) for slow breathing.
- Help beyond this book: counsellors, helplines and support groups.

- The library: the stress response (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/stress), the window of tolerance, sleep and mood, going over and over things (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), catastrophising (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/thinking) and loneliness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).

More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life
- For teens · For parents · New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- At work
- Not safe at home?
- **More in Part Three:** Stress (page 7) · Self-worth and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth) · Healing (page 83)
- Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship): find the pages for your situation.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- ✓ **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 2. Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.
- ✓ **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- ✓ **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system page 7
The stress ladder and rest

Book 1 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion Know Yourself Kindly
A kinder inner voice

Book 3 · Helping others well Understanding Each Other
Supporting someone who is struggling

Book 1 · Your wiring, weather and words Know Yourself Kindly
Checking your weather each day

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth

4

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 4 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 8

Loss, grief and big life changes

What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves, not stages.** A good week and then a bad day is normal, not going backwards.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that's healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help. Both are normal.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **Who did what and the setup score** (the Preface to Part Two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/preface); Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2)) help after a death, an illness, a move or a new baby, because a big change quietly moves jobs from one person to another. Looking at the month again lets you share the new load on purpose. Big idea: *see the whole load.*
- **"A full tank means later, not never"** (Part Two, Chapter III (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-3)) fits grief: grief fills the tank, so some talks wait for a better day, with a time named.
- **Where your lens came from** (Part One, Then (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then)) looks at older losses that still shape how you react today.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

Six months on, you're doing fine. Then, in the supermarket, you see the cereal your dad always bought, and you have to leave your trolley in the aisle and sit in the car. Nobody around you knows. It feels like day one again.

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something: a person, a pet, a marriage, a friendship, health, a home, a job, a country or a future you had pictured. It explains how grief works first, then what can help. There is no right way to grieve, and nothing here is a timetable.

01

Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone. It isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted, or children leaving home can all bring real grief. The size of the grief usually matches the size of the bond, not what other people think the loss "should" mean.

For example: A man is surprised how hard he takes his dog's death. His friends say "it was just a dog." But that dog walked with him every morning for twelve years.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This hurts because it mattered." "My grief doesn't need anyone's permission."

TRY THIS:

Name one loss you've been carrying that you haven't called grief. Say it to yourself: "I'm grieving…"

02

Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages: denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance. They came from listening to dying patients, and were never meant as steps everyone follows in order. Most people swing back and forth: some hours deep in the loss, some hours getting on with life. That back-and-forth is healthy. Laughing at a funeral, or having a good day, doesn't mean you've stopped caring.

For example: A widow feels guilty that she enjoyed lunch with her sister. Then she cries all evening. Both were grief doing its work.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"A good hour isn't a betrayal." "This is a wave. Waves pass."

TRY THIS:

Let yourself have one small break from grief today, without guilt: a walk, a show, a meal with a friend.

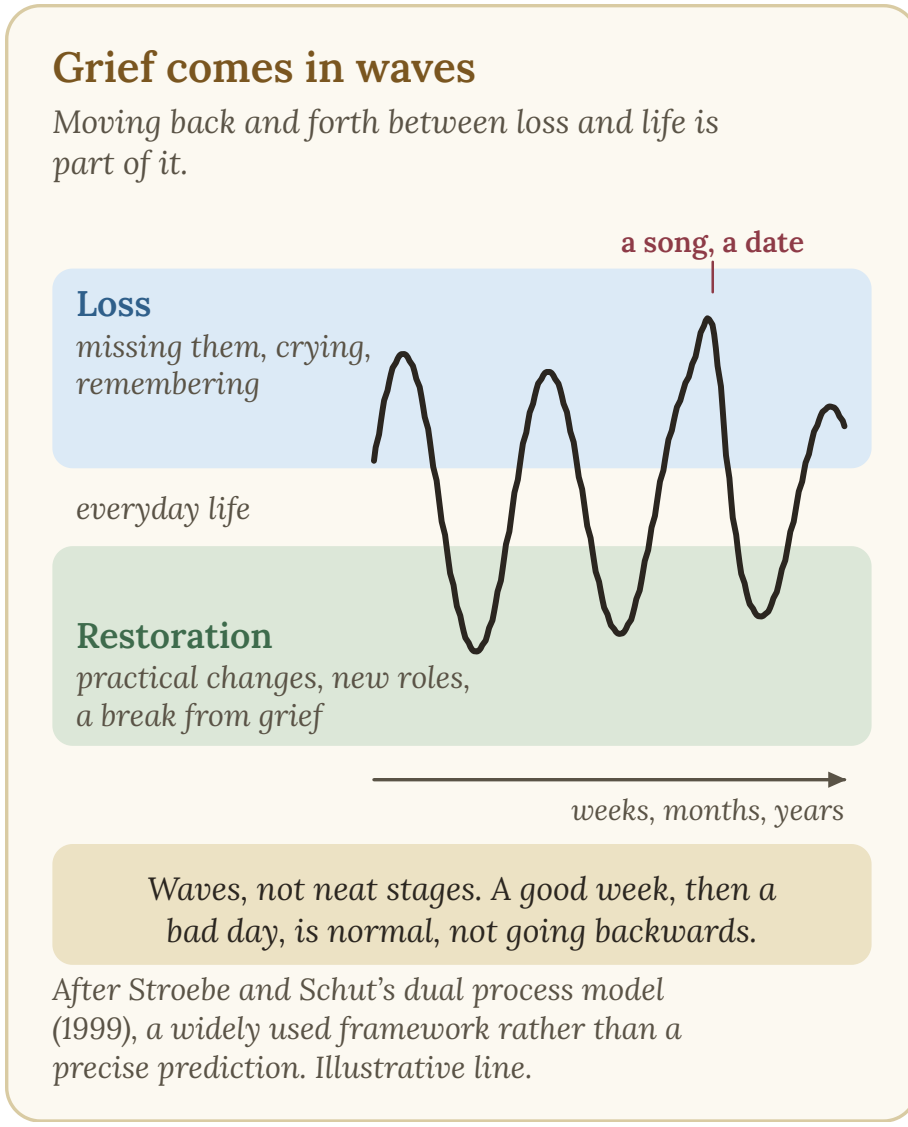


FIGURE 5 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

03

Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, poor sleep, no appetite or extra appetite, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there

isn't. That takes time, and it uses energy.

For example: A teacher whose mother died keeps losing her keys and forgetting meetings. She worries something is wrong with her memory. It's grief fog, and it eases as the months pass.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm grieving, so I'm slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?"

TRY THIS:

Pick three basics to protect this week: one regular meal, a set bedtime, and a short walk outside.

04

Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain. Someone is still alive but changed, through dementia, addiction or illness. Someone is gone but not dead, like an estranged parent or a missing relative. Some losses aren't recognised by others: an ex-partner's death, a pregnancy loss, a friend you met online. Grief without a ceremony, or without other people noticing, can feel very lonely.

For example: A woman's father has dementia. He's still here, and she still visits, but the dad who knew her is fading. She's grieving someone who hasn't died.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm grieving something people might not see as a loss. It is one for me."

TRY THIS:

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, make a small one: light a candle, write a letter, plant something, visit a place.

05

People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying. Others grieve by doing: fixing, organising, working, building something. Neither is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks the other "isn't grieving" when they are just grieving differently. Culture, faith, age and how your mind works all shape it, too.

For example: After their son's death, one parent wants to talk about him every evening. The other spends weekends restoring his old bike. Each feels the other is getting it wrong. Both are grieving him.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we grieve differently. Can you tell me what helps you, and I'll tell you what helps me?"

TRY THIS:

Ask someone who shares your loss: "What has helped you most, even a little?" Listen without correcting.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Talk it through in writing

Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Malcolm and Fiona

Your name (optional)
Mum

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)
How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.

How I feel about it

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)
Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll ring you if I need you in between?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Fiona rang the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.

Fill in your own: Talk it through in writing
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

06

You don't have to let go.

An older idea said healthy grief meant "moving on" and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently: people often keep a bond with who they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head, and values they carry forward. The relationship changes shape. It doesn't have to end.

For example: A teenager wears her grandfather's watch to exams. She doesn't believe in luck. It just feels like he's with her.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What would they say about this?" "I carry this part of them with me."

TRY THIS:

Choose one way to keep a bond: cook their recipe, tell a story about them, or keep one of their habits.

07

Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retirement, moving country, a child starting school, coming out, or getting well after a long illness can all bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts: an ending, a confusing in-between time, and a new beginning. The middle part is the hardest, and the easiest to rush.

For example: A couple moves to a new city for a great job. Six months in, one of them feels low and guilty: "We wanted this." They also lost friends, a favourite café and a whole way of life.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I can be glad about this and still miss what came before." "I'm in the in-between. It's supposed to feel unsettled."

TRY THIS:

For one change you're going through, write: what ended, what feels unclear, and one small thing that's new and good.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a change is hard to talk about, writing can come first. This is a quiet place to put the words down, at your own pace, and to send them only if you want to.

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

08

Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that many people, over time, find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, even though they never forget. Being with people who let you talk, or not talk, helps. For some, though, grief stays stuck at full strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**: a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (usually a year or more for adults) and getting in the way of life. That isn't weakness, and there is specific help for it.

For example: A year after his wife died, a man still can't go into their bedroom or see friends. His doctor refers him to a grief counsellor. Slowly, things begin to move.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"It's been a long time and it isn't getting any easier. I think I need more help."

TRY THIS:

Write down two people you could text on a hard day, and one place you could call if those people aren't enough.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

You sit in the car for ten minutes and let the wave come. Then you go back in, and you buy the cereal. At home you text your sister: "Saw Dad's cereal in the shop and cried in the car park." She replies straight away: "Same thing happened to me with his aftershave. Call tonight?" The wave doesn't mean you're back at day one. It means he's still part of your Saturdays.

Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage, the loss is in everything: the empty chair, the jobs that were always theirs, the paperwork done alone, the first birthday and anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time. One drawer counts. Ask someone to sit with you for the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent, and you have lost a partner. You may grieve on different timetables. If they start checking on you every day, that comes from love and worry, not control. You can still say what helps: "I love that you ring. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll ring you if I need you?"

In everyday life

- **Partners:** After a miscarriage, one partner wants to talk and the other goes quiet. Each worries the other doesn't care.
- **Parents and children:** A child laughs and plays the day after a funeral, then cries at bedtime. Both are grief.
- **Friends:** A friend stops calling after your diagnosis, not from coldness but because they don't know what to say.

- **Work:** A colleague returns after a death and everyone avoids the subject. She feels her loss has been erased.
- **Community:** A neighbourhood loses its library, or a town loses its factory, and many people grieve the same thing together.

On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely, even with people around. Some things help when you're carrying it alone:

- Give the day a small shape: one meal, one walk, one person you message.
- Expect harder days around dates, and plan something gentle for them.
- Write to who you lost, or about what you lost. Nobody else needs to read it.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "I don't have to do this fast." "Today I only need to get to tonight."

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED: Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief) goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, try For a hard evening.

Common mix-ups

- **"There are five stages, in order."** Most people go back and forth. There is no correct order.
- **"After a year you should be over it."** Grief changes over time, but there's no deadline. Anniversaries and birthdays often bring it back.
- **"If I'm not crying, I'm not grieving."** Some people grieve by doing, thinking or staying busy. That counts.
- **"Moving on means forgetting."** You can build a new life and keep a bond with who you lost.
- **"Good changes shouldn't make me sad."** Every change ends something. Missing the old life is normal.
- **"I shouldn't mention their name, it'll upset them."** Many grieving people say hearing the name is a comfort. Ask.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Show up, and keep showing up.** Support often floods in for two weeks and then stops. A text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal.
- **Offer something specific.** "Can I drop off dinner on Thursday?" is easier to say yes to than "let me know if you need anything."
- **Say the name.** Share a memory. Let them talk, or not.
- **Don't fix or explain.** Skip "everything happens for a reason" and "at least…". Try "I'm so sorry. I'm here."
- **Comfort in, vent out.** If you're upset too, lean on people further from the loss, not on those closest to it.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mum today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop, what can I bring you?"

When to get more help

Grief is not an illness. But it's worth talking to a doctor or a grief counsellor if, after many months, the pain isn't easing at all, you can't manage daily life, you feel life has no meaning without the person, or you are drinking or using other things to get through. Many hospices, faith communities and charities offer free bereavement support, including for children.

If you are having thoughts of not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If a loss involved violence, or you are grieving a relationship you left because you weren't safe, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help, including after you separate.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a wave that feels too big

Reading pages to read on the website

- Calm sounds (spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes) for a quiet few minutes
- Grief and later life: loss, family and a new chapter, with a page for a hard evening
- Grief and change (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions) and ambiguous loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life), in the site's library of research notes
- Moving and life transitions and writing about hard things
- After a loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), in your self-discovery path

More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family · Family rifts after a loss or a will (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve · For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Big changes:** Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · Retired together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together) · Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · New parent (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Caring for someone you love (spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers)
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)

- **More in Part Three:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth) · Minds that work differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- ✓ **It comes in waves, not stages.** A good week and then a bad day is normal, not going backwards.
- ✓ **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that's healthy.
- ✓ **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help. Both are normal.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3 · Attachment, trust and belonging
Why losing a bond hurts so much — Understanding Each Other

Book 3 · Helping others well
Supporting someone who is grieving — Understanding Each Other

Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When grief turns into low mood — page 45

Book 1 · Where your lens came from
Losses that shaped your lens — Know Yourself Kindly

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Calm sounds
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss-in-depth

5

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 5 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 11

Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help

How hurt heals: why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, what forgiveness is and isn't, and when it's time to get more help.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice. Safety comes first
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying it doesn't mean you're weak. It means it mattered.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.
- **Forgiveness isn't going back.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.

- **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **"Get back in tune before you carry on" and "go back in with a clear sentence"** (Part Two, Chapter I (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-1)) are repair in small: breaks are normal, and coming back is the skill. Big idea: *tune how you send and receive.*
- **The monthly look-back** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) includes "look back even when nothing is slipping", because small hurts repaired early don't harden into resentment.

THURSDAY, 2AM

It was one sentence, three weeks ago. They've probably forgotten it. You haven't. It plays again, word for word, and you think of all the things you could have said back. You're tired of carrying it, and you don't know how to put it down.

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter explains how hurt works, how relationships mend, and how you can heal, with or without the other person. It's for small hurts and bigger ones. If someone is hurting you on purpose, or you feel afraid, start with safety first: Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

01

Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered: the person, your trust, your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it's trying to understand them and keep you safe. Healing isn't a straight line. The feeling can come back on an anniversary, or when something reminds you. That doesn't mean you've failed. It means you're still healing.

For example (on your own): Months after a friend said something cruel at a party, Kwesi feels a jolt when he hears that song again. He reminds himself: "That's an old bruise being pressed, not a new wound."

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

TRY THIS:
When a hurt replays, notice it, name it ("there's that memory again"), and gently bring your attention to something in the room you can see or touch.

02

Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time. People snap, forget, misread and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy all points the same way: breaks are normal. What matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, done soon, often makes a relationship feel safer than if the break had never happened.

For example (a parent and child): Dad snaps at his son for spilling juice. Twenty minutes later he sits down next to him: "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair. Spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?"

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can I have a do-over? That came out badly." "I didn't like how I spoke to you earlier. I'm sorry."

> TRY THIS:
> Think of a small break this week, with anyone. Go back and repair it with one sentence.

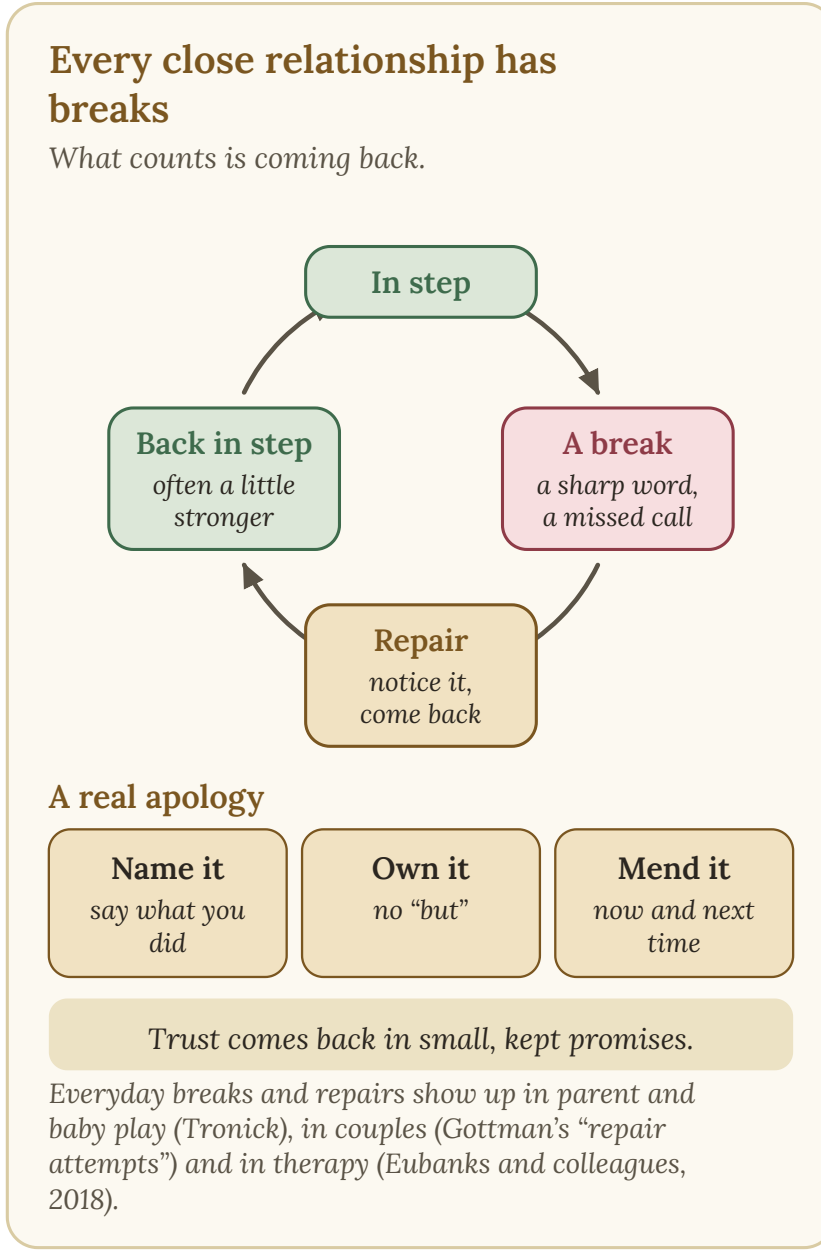


FIGURE 6 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

03

Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance. It works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, rather than what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, not the middle of an argument.

For example (a friend): Amara says to her friend: "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." She didn't call her friend a gossip. She said what happened and what she needs.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"When… happened, I felt… What I'd like is…" "I'm telling you because I want us to be okay."

TRY THIS:

Write your sentence before you say it: what happened, how you felt, what you'd like. Keep it to three short lines.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Talk it through in writing

Carys, writing to her brother Owen

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Owen

Your name (optional)
Carys

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)

At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

I'm not angry with you as a person.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.

Fill in your own: Talk it through in writing

(spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through)

04

A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand how it affected the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

For example (a coworker): Leila presented a shared idea in a meeting as if it were hers. The next day she tells her colleague: "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll email the team today and say it was joint work."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I did… That was my doing. I can see it left you feeling… Here's what I'll do."

TRY THIS:

Next time you say sorry, check for the four parts: what I did, it was mine, how it affected you, what I'll do now. See Apology languages (spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages) for more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. The step-by-step reset can help you find those words.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even. It's something that happens inside you. It doesn't mean saying what happened was okay. It doesn't mean forgetting. And it doesn't mean you have to trust the person again or have them in your life. Forgiveness is a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on someone else's timetable.

For example (a grown-up child and a parent): Danielle forgave her father for missing much of her childhood. She still keeps visits short, and she still doesn't leave her kids alone with him when he drinks. Forgiving him and protecting her family both feel right.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

TRY THIS:

Write down what forgiving someone would mean to you, and what it would not mean. Seeing the difference can make it feel possible, or show you that you aren't ready, which is fine too.

06

You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck. The person may be gone, unwilling, or unable to understand. Healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe, and decide what it means for you now.

For example (an ex-partner): After a hard breakup, Martha writes a letter she never sends. She says everything: what hurt, what she

wished, what she's taking with her. Then she puts it away. Nothing changed for him. Something shifted for her.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
"I don't need them to understand for my healing to count."

TRY THIS:
Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes, three or four days in a row. Write about the facts and your feelings. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop, and talk to someone instead.

07

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in many small moments where someone does what they said they'd do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture. If you were let down, it's fair to watch what someone does, not just what they say.

For example (partners): Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner. After it came out, he offered to share his bank statements each month, without being asked. After a year of small, steady openness, his partner says she can breathe again.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I know my words aren't enough. I want to show you, over time." "I need to see it for a while before I can feel it."

TRY THIS:
If you're rebuilding trust, choose one small promise you can keep every week, and keep it.

08

Going back is a choice. Safety comes first.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship, change its shape, or step away. All three can be healthy. If someone keeps hurting you after you've told them, if you feel afraid of them, or if they control, threaten or put you down, the work is to protect yourself, not to repair. Counselling together isn't advised when someone is afraid of their partner.

For example (housemates): Ellie's housemate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie forgave the first time. The second time, she said: "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get on in the house." A limit, not a war.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not angry any more, and I'm not going back to how it was."
> "I need some distance while I work out what I want."

> TRY THIS:
> Ask yourself three questions: Is it safe? Has the hurt stopped? Do I want this relationship in my life? Your answers can guide what comes next. If you feel unsafe, see signs to look out for.

09

Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind: poor sleep, a tight chest, feeling jumpy. Healing goes better with basic care: rest, food, movement, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a hurting friend. Some people find they grow after something painful. That can happen, but it's not a test you have to pass.

For example (a stranger): A man shouted at Idris on the bus, calling him names. For days he felt shaky. He told a friend, went for long

walks, and said to himself, “That was about him, not me. I’m safe now.” Slowly, the shakiness faded.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
“This was hard. Anyone would be shaken. What do I need right now?”

TRY THIS:
Pick one small act of care for today: an early night, a walk, a warm drink, a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologise for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can’t make someone apologise, understand or change, and you don’t have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

You’ve written it all down, every word of it. Then a smaller version: “When you said that, I felt small. I’d like you to know.” You haven’t decided whether to send it. But the 2am replays have gone quieter, because now it’s on paper, not just in your head.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Writing the hurt down, every word, then a shorter version, can quieten the replays. You don’t have to send

it.

- **With a partner:** Small breaks happen daily. A quick "That came out wrong. Can I try again?" mends most of them. See How to apologise so it counts.
- **Family:** Old family hurts often need a different talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. See Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts).
- **Friends:** A friend may not know they hurt you. "Can I tell you something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift." keeps the door open.
- **At work:** Keep it to the facts and what you need next time. A short note afterwards helps both of you remember the same thing.
- **After someone has died:** You can still heal a hurt with someone who is gone, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust. See Grief and later life (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief).
- **After an affair:** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months, and a couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth).
- **If you decide to separate:** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation where it's safe. More in the full chapter.

Common mix-ups

- **"If I forgive, I'm saying it was okay."** Forgiving isn't excusing. You can forgive and still say it was wrong.
- **"If I forgive, I have to let them back in."** Forgiveness and going back are separate choices.
- **"A good relationship never has breaks."** Every close relationship has them. Mending them is what builds safety.
- **"Saying sorry means it's fixed."** An apology opens the door. Trust comes back through what happens next.
- **"I should be over this by now."** Healing has no deadline. Feelings returning doesn't mean you're back at the start.
- **"I can't heal unless they admit it."** Their apology can help, but your healing can go ahead without it.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Listen before you advise.** "That sounds really painful" helps more than "You should just let it go."
- **Don't rush forgiveness.** Pushing someone to forgive can feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter.
- **Don't push them to cut someone off, either.** It's their relationship and their choice, unless they're in danger.
- **If you caused the hurt,** give a real apology and then give them time. Don't ask them to make you feel better about it.
- **If they mention fear, threats or control,** take it seriously and share Not safe at home?

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

When to get more help

Some hurts are too heavy to carry alone, and getting help is a sign of strength, not weakness. Think about talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if:

- More than a month after something frightening, you still have flashbacks, nightmares, feel constantly on edge, or avoid places and people that remind you of it. These can be signs of trauma, and there are well-tested treatments for it, such as trauma-focused talking therapies.
- The hurt is taking over: you can't sleep, work or enjoy anything, or you're drinking or using more to cope.
- The hurt came from abuse or violence, now or in the past. The page Free, private people to talk to includes specialist lines.
- You're having thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else. Please reach out today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If anyone is in danger now, call your local emergency number.

If you and someone else both want to mend things, a couples or family counsellor can help, as long as nobody is afraid of the other.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks) for checking your state.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Apology languages: how to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness.
- Library: forgiveness (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/conflict), what research says about apologies and repair attempts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/relationships).
- Library: rumination (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/emotions), expressive writing and self-compassion (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/connection).
- Stories from philosophy: the Second Arrow (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth).

More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts · For grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- **After a breakup:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting)
- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life

- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

More in Part Three

← Chapter 10: Values, meaning and a good life (page 119) · Chapter 12: Helping others well → (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-12-helping) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy, and it isn't a reason to stay somewhere unsafe. If you're afraid of someone, the most healing step is getting safe. Not safe at home?

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying it doesn't mean you're weak. It means it mattered.
- ✓ **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.
- ✓ **Forgiveness isn't going back.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- ✓ **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4 · Two kinds of fair
Covering kindly and saying it out loud
Share the Load

Book 3 · How communication works
Repair in everyday talk
Understanding Each Other

Chapter 2 · Anger
When anger did the damage
page 27

Book 1 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Guilt without shame
Know Yourself Kindly

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Apology languages
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth

6

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 6 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 6

Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- **Small and set up beats big and willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change the setup around you.
- **Slips are part of change.** A missed day is information about the plan, not proof about you.

- **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it. You can't force it.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **One small step a week** (the six-week program; Part One, Next (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next)) works because change that lasts starts smaller than feels useful, and an if-then plan does the deciding ahead of time.
- **The setup score and One owner per job** (Part Two, Chapter II (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-2); Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) change the setup instead of asking for more willpower. Habits follow cues and easy paths. Big ideas: *fix the setup, not the person* and *notice the quiet incentives.*
- **What keeps coming back?** (Part Two, Chapter V (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-5)) treats a repeat as information, not failure, because slips are a normal part of change.

MONDAY, 7:05AM

The plan was a walk before work. The trainers are by the door. But the phone is in your hand, and somehow it's 7:40 and you're scrolling with cold coffee. By evening, a quiet voice says: "See? You never stick to anything." That voice is wrong. You aren't weak. You've met a habit.

01

Change is hard for good reasons.

Much of what we do each day runs on autopilot. That saves energy, which is why habits exist. The downside is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one. Change asks your brain to do something effortful, again and again, until the new way becomes the easy one.

For example: Jodie wants to stop snapping at her kids in the morning rush. She means it every night. Every morning, the same rush brings the same snap. She isn't a bad parent; the morning is a well-worn groove.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "This is hard because it's a habit, not because I'm failing." "Old grooves take time to fill in."

TRY THIS:
Pick one thing you'd like to change and write: "When does it usually happen? Where? What's going on just before?"

02

Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger: a time, a place, a feeling, a person, or the thing you just did. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward (relief, comfort, a little buzz) keeps it going. If you know the cue, you can plan for it.

For example: A man notices he reaches for snacks not when he's hungry but when he opens his laptop after dinner. The cue is the laptop. He starts making tea first instead.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

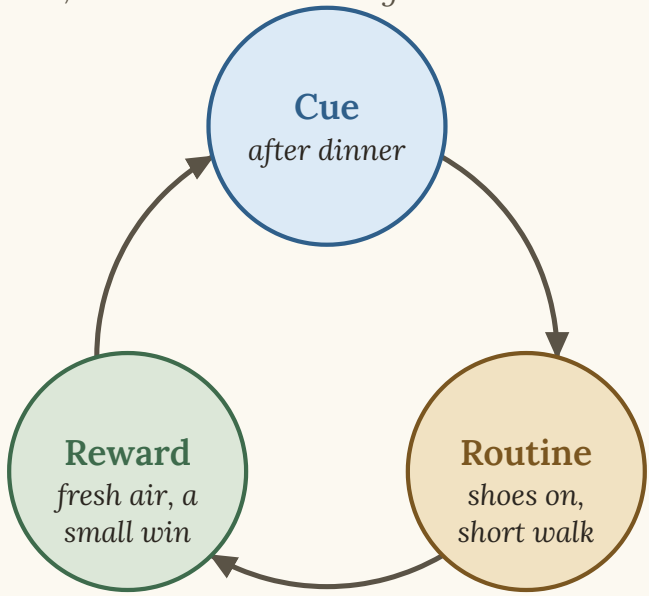
"What happened right before I did that?" "What was I getting from it?"

TRY THIS:

For three days, each time the habit happens, jot down the cue: time, place, feeling, or what you were doing.

Habits run on cues

Over time, the cue alone is enough.



Change the setup, not just your willpower: *move the cue, make the step tiny.*

The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).

FIGURE 7 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring but easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and that's why they work: they're easy enough to do on a bad day. Tie the new step to something you already do: "After I put the kettle on, I'll..." Once it sticks, you can grow it.

For example: Two housemates want a tidier kitchen. Instead of a big weekly clean they never do, they agree: "After dinner, we each wipe one surface." It takes two minutes, and the kitchen stays nicer.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I ..., I will ..."

TRY THIS:

Shrink your change until it takes two minutes or less. Write it as "After I ___, I will ___."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

Your done list

Bernie, 71, living on his own

Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe

Who it was with

With a friend

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Rang my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the post office instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.

Fill in your own: Your done list (spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins)

04

Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when we're tired, hungry or stressed. Your surroundings don't. Make the new habit easier (put it in sight, get things ready the night before) and the old one a little harder (move it out of reach, add a step). Small changes to your setup can do more than any amount of trying harder.

For example: A teenager wants to sleep better. Instead of "trying not to scroll," he charges his phone in the kitchen. It works far better than willpower ever did.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

(to yourself or a partner) "What could we change about the setup so this gets easier?"

TRY THIS:

Make one small change to your space today that makes the new habit easier or the old one harder.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.



WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change. Part of you doesn't, and that part usually has its reasons: the old habit gives comfort, saves effort, or protects you from something. Pushing harder against that part rarely works. Listening to it often does.

For example: Asif wants to drink less, but he also loves the Friday pub with his team. Instead of "never again," he asks what Friday gives him: friends, laughing, unwinding. He keeps the Friday, and switches to alcohol-free after the first drink.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"What does the old habit give me?" "What would make the change worth it to me, not just to others?"

TRY THIS:

Write two lists: "What I like about how things are" and "What I'd like about changing." Both lists are allowed.

06

Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes. One slip doesn't undo your progress. What often does is the thought that follows: "I've blown it, so why bother?" Treating yourself kindly after a slip makes it more likely you'll start again, not less.

For example: After three calm weeks, a dad shouts at his son over homework. That night he says, "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." The next day he's back on track. The slip became a repair, not a reason to give up.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"A slip is a moment, not a verdict." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

TRY THIS:

Decide now what you'll do after a slip: one kind sentence to yourself, and one small step to start again.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: a slip is a stumble, not a fall. Shake it off and try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts makes practising more fun!

TOOL **Calm football game for small kind acts** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change done only to please others, or out of shame, is hard to keep. Change that connects to what you care about, the kind of person, parent, friend or colleague you want to be, has deeper roots. Each small action is a vote for that person.

For example: A woman who wants to "be better at keeping in touch" reframes it: "I'm someone who shows up for my friends." Sending one voice note a week becomes part of who she is, not a chore.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Who am I becoming with this step?" "This matters to me because..."

TRY THIS:

Finish this sentence for your change: "I want to do this because I care about..."

08

You can support change, but not force it.

It's natural to want people we love to change: to drink less, tidy more, look after themselves. But other people's change belongs to them. Pressure tends to make people dig in. What helps more: saying clearly what you need, asking what would help, and noticing their small steps out loud.

For example: A coworker keeps missing deadlines. Instead of "You need to be more organised," his teammate asks, "What would make the handover easier for you?" They set up a shared checklist, and the deadlines improve.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I can't change this for you, but I'd love to help if you want me to." "I noticed you did that this week. That really helped."

TRY THIS:

Notice one small positive change someone else made this week, and tell them.

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

The trainers are still by the door, but the phone now charges in the kitchen overnight. The plan has shrunk too: shoes on and out to the end of the road. Some mornings that's all. Most mornings it turns into a walk. On the day you miss, the voice says "See?" and you answer it: "A missed day is a slip, not a verdict. Tomorrow, the end of the road."

In everyday life

- **Partners:** One partner wants to spend less time on phones in the evening. They agree on a basket for both phones after nine, not a rule for one person.
- **Parents and children:** A picture chart of the bedtime steps makes a new routine easier for a young child than reminders ever did.
- **Friends:** Two friends who want to move more meet for a Saturday walk. The friendship is the reward that keeps the habit going.
- **Coworkers:** A team that keeps forgetting actions starts ending every meeting with "Who does what by when?" It's a tiny habit with a big effect.
- **Housemates:** A shared list on the fridge works better than anyone trying to remember.
- **Big life changes:** A move, a new baby or a new job breaks old routines. That's disruptive, and it's also a good moment to start new habits.
- **If you have ADHD:** Make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears, and make the reward come now. Expect novelty to wear off and swap the method, rather than blaming

yourself. More in the full chapter (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth).

On your own: a kind plan for change

If you're working on something alone, put the ideas together in one small plan:

- **One change.** Not five. Pick the one that would make the most difference, or the one that feels most doable.
- **One cue.** "After I ___, I will ___."
- **One setup tweak.** Make it easier to start.
- **One tired-day version.** The smallest version you can still do on a bad day.
- **One kind sentence for slips.** Written down, ready to use.

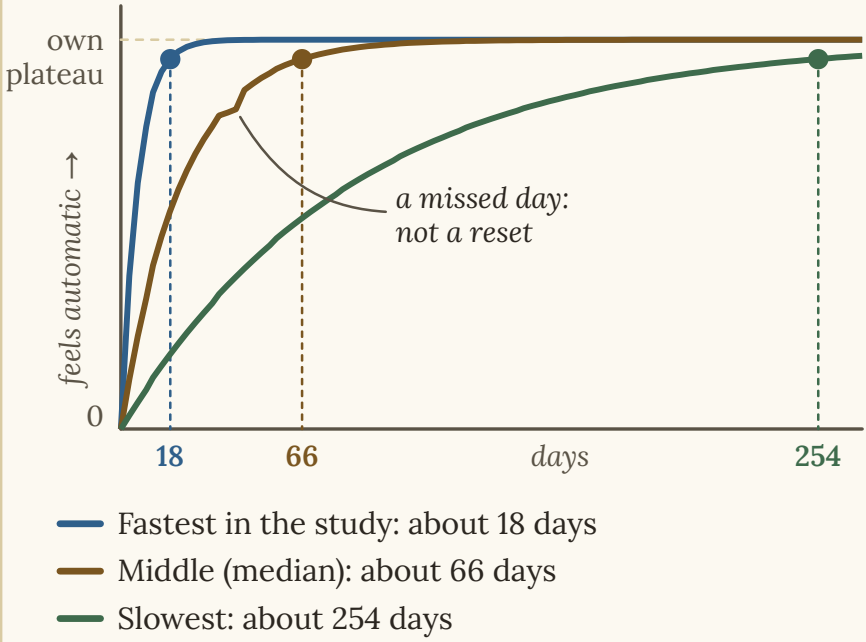
The individual program walks through this step by step: The self path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) and Know yourself, next.

Common mix-ups

- **"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it."** Wanting is only the start. Habits, setup, tiredness and stress all matter.
- **"It takes 21 days to form a habit."** There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range.
- **"One slip means I've failed."** Slips are normal. Starting again is the skill.
- **"Being hard on myself will keep me on track."** Harshness tends to make people give up. Kindness makes it easier to try again.
- **"If I nag enough, they'll change."** Pressure often makes people dig in. Ask, support and notice instead.
- **"Routines mean being rigid."** For many people, especially autistic people, routines are what make life manageable. Change can respect that.

About two months, give or take a lot

How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.



Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.

FIGURE 8 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Ask before advising.** "Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?"

- **Help them find their own reasons.** "What would be different for you if this changed?"
- **Help with the setup.** Offer practical things: a lift to the gym, a shared calendar, a quieter evening.
- **Notice small steps out loud.** Encouragement for small wins often helps more than pointing out what's still missing.
- **Be kind about slips.** "That's okay, tomorrow's a new go" helps more than "I knew it."
- **Look after yourself.** You can care deeply and still set limits on what you'll put up with.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days running. That's not nothing."

When to get more help

- **If a habit is harming your health or life,** such as drinking, drugs, gambling, eating or self-harm, please talk to a doctor or a specialist service. Needing help with this is common and nothing to be ashamed of.
- **If you can't stop even though you've tried many times,** professional support can make a real difference. It isn't a sign of weakness.
- **If change feels impossible because you're exhausted or low most days,** that may be burnout or depression. A doctor or counsellor can help.
- **If someone is demanding you change in ways that frighten you,** or punishing you when you don't, that isn't support. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

- **If you're overwhelmed right now**, start with Upset right now (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now).

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

PRACTICE:
pick one tiny change and try it for a week.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Know yourself, next: values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans.
- Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency): why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive.

More for your situation

- On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own)
- New parents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent)
- When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids)
- Neurodivergent relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships)
- Gaming, phones and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work)
- Coming home after time apart (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home)
- Find it by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship)

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- ✓ **Small and set up beats big and willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change the setup around you.
- ✓ **Slips are part of change.** A missed day is information about the plan, not proof about you.
- ✓ **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it. You can't force it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Who you are becoming — Know Yourself Kindly
One small goal and tiny steps

Book 4 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load
The monthly look-back

Book 4 · Is the split working? — Share the Load
Changing the setup, not the person

Book 1 · Personality, temperament and change — Know Yourself Kindly
How much people really change

PUT IT TO USE



Know yourself, next
Values, one small goal, tiny steps and if-then plans
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next



Complacency
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth

7

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 7 · ONLINE: PART THREE · CHAPTER 10

Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Values are directions, not finish lines
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Values are directions, not finish lines.** You never "complete" kindness. You keep turning towards it.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness; hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.
- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK: this chapter explains the thinking behind these tools from earlier in the book.

- **"Two kinds of fair"** (Part Two, Chapter IV (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/chapter-4)) works because people value different good things. Agreeing which kind of fair you mean stops two good values fighting. Big idea: *notice the quiet incentives.*
- **"Start with what matters to you"** (Part One, Next (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next)) turns a value into one small goal, because values are directions, not finish lines.

SUNDAY, 9PM

The week ahead is full, and none of it feels like yours. You're not sad, exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, and not because it was next on the list.

This chapter is about values: the things you care about, the direction you want your life to face, and what makes a life feel good and worth living. It borrows from psychology, and from philosophy, which has been asking "how should I live?" for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it. Everything here is in plain words.

01

Values are directions, not finish lines.

A goal is something you can tick off: run a 5k, paint the hall, pass the test. A value is a direction you keep walking in: looking after your health, making your home feel cared for, being a fair friend.

You never "finish" kindness. That's why values still work on the days when goals fall apart.

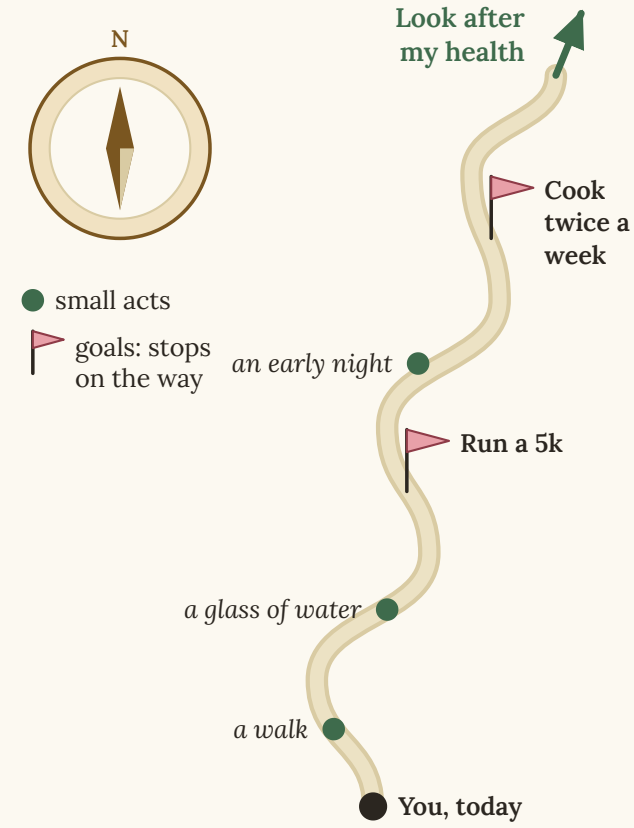
For example (on your own): Bethan planned to go to the gym three times this week and went once. She felt like a failure. Then she asked what the goal was for: "looking after my body, so I have energy for my kids." She walked for twenty minutes at lunch. The goal slipped. The direction didn't.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
> "What is this goal for? What do I care about underneath it?" "I can't do the big thing today. What's one small step in the same direction?"

> TRY THIS:
> Pick one goal you have. Ask "what is this for?" three times in a row, and write down where you end up.

Values are directions

A goal can be finished. A value is a direction you keep facing.



Missing a goal is a missed stop.
The direction is still there.

Illustration. Acceptance and commitment therapy treats values as "chosen life directions", with goals as milestones.

FIGURE 9 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way; missing one doesn't change the direction.

02

Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from nothing. They show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means something you care about has been stepped on. Envy can point to something you want for yourself. Sadness often shows what you love. A feeling is a signal, and a value is often what it's pointing at.

For example (a coworker): Sacha is furious when a colleague takes credit for the team's work. Under the anger is a value: fairness, and seeing people's effort. Once Sacha names it, he can talk about fairness in the next meeting, instead of just being angry at one person.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think I'm upset because fairness really matters to me. It isn't about wanting to win."

> TRY THIS:
> Think of the last time you felt strongly, good or bad. Finish this sentence: "That mattered to me because I care about…"

03

Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices aren't good against bad. They are good against good: honesty and kindness, freedom and safety, family and rest. Feeling torn doesn't mean you're confused or weak. It means you care about more than one thing. Even when you choose well, it's normal to feel a little sad about the side you didn't choose.

For example (a parent and child): A mum cares about being honest and about protecting her eight-year-old. When the family dog is very ill, she doesn't pick one. She tells the truth, gently, in words a

child can hold: “Biscuit is very poorly. The vet is helping, and we’ll look after him together.”

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:
“Which two good things are pulling at me here?” “Can I honour some of both, even if I can’t have all of either?”

TRY THIS:
Name a choice you feel stuck on. Write the good thing on each side. Notice how it feels to see that you’re torn between two goods, not between right and wrong.

04

Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago, a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren’t. Your own choices, effort and how you treat people are up to you. Other people’s choices, the weather and the past are not. Worry often goes to the second pile. Values live in the first.

For example (a partner): Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas with her family. She can’t make him enjoy it. She can plan a shorter visit, include a walk he’ll like, and be warm herself. That’s her part, and it’s enough.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
“I can’t make this go well. I can choose how I show up.”

TRY THIS:
Write one worry in two columns: the parts that are up to you, and the parts that aren’t. Pick one small thing from the first column and do it.

05

A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. But many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists today, describe a second kind of wellbeing: growing, using your strengths, being a good friend, and doing things that matter even when they're hard. Aristotle called it flourishing. He thought we build it the way we build any skill: by practice, a little at a time.

For example (a friend): Jade spent a month helping a friend move out of a bad flat. It was tiring and not much fun. But looking back, she says it was one of the best months of her year. It wasn't pleasant. It was worthwhile.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Was today a good day, or a worthwhile day? Both count."

TRY THIS:

Tonight, write down one thing that felt good today and one thing that felt worthwhile. Notice whether they are the same thing.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If you enjoy big questions, try putting philosophy next to psychology and see what they share. It's one of my favourite rainy-day games.

TOOL **Connect two fields of study** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

06

Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts. Your life makes some sense to you. You are heading somewhere. And your life matters to someone. Most meaning doesn't come from big

moments. It comes from people, from work done with care, and from small roles that others count on.

For example (in the community): Walter is retired and lives alone since his wife died. His days went quiet. Now he reads to children at the library one morning a week. It gives him a reason to iron a shirt, and people who notice when he isn't there.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

"Who would notice if I didn't show up? Who do I show up for?"

TRY THIS:

List three roles you play, big or small: neighbour, sister, the one who waters the office plants. Next to each, write who it matters to.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Keep your little rituals alive

Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together

Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
Lachlan

Person B
Sunita

Date
2 October 2026

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way
Monday coffee call, cameras optional	*Weekly*	*Fading*	*Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30*

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way
Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat	*Weekly*	*Alive*	*Five minutes; people notice each other's work*
A card and lunch when someone leaves	*Now and then*	*Alive*	*People leave feeling thanked*
Office day with lunch together	*Monthly*	*Stopped*	*Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests*
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day	*Daily*	*New idea*	*So nobody wonders who's around*

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

Your rituals
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

Fading or stopped
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

New ideas
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
Monday coffee call

The smallest version that still counts
Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual
Office day with lunch together

What it gave us
A day all together, back when we all lived near the office

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15)

07

Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order. One puts safety first; another puts adventure first. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life, and they can't all be ranked on one scale. That leaves room to disagree without either person being bad.

For example (housemates): Jasper values a calm, tidy home. His housemate Darnell values an open door and friends dropping by. For months it was "messy" against "uptight." Once they named the values, it became a plan: open house on Fridays, quiet Sundays.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we care about different good things here. Can we each say what matters to us about it?"

TRY THIS:

In your next disagreement, ask: “What matters to you about this?” Listen for the value, not just the position.

08

Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again: how you greet people, whether you keep small promises, how you talk about someone who isn’t in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become. Later thinkers who wrote about care said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you.

For example (a stranger): At the supermarket, an older man is struggling with the card machine. You wait without sighing, and say “No rush.” It costs forty seconds. It might be the kindest moment of his day.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY:

“What would the person I want to be do in the next five minutes?” “When I drift from my values, I don’t need to punish myself. I just turn back.”

TRY THIS:

Pick one value. Choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it each day this week.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot’s tip: a value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A care card helps you learn what feels like care to each of you.

TOOL **What feels like care to me: a care card** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can choose your direction, notice when you drift, and turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

You write three words on the back of an envelope: "people, health, making things." Then one small thing for this week under each: call Gran, walk on Wednesday, finish the shelf. The week is still full. But now some of it is yours.

In everyday life

- **On your own:** Three words on an envelope can be enough. Look at them on Sunday and pick one small thing for each. See Part One, Next.
- **With a partner:** You may rank the same values differently, like security and adventure. Say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan.
- **Family:** Two generations can both value "family" and mean different things by it: being close by, or being free to go. Ask what it means to them.
- **Friends:** Friendships often rest on one shared value, like loyalty or fun. Naming it can help when life pulls you apart. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **At work:** When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain shows up as tiredness or cynicism. Naming the clash is a

first step. See At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work).

- **In your community:** Volunteering, a faith group or a club can be a place to act on a value with other people.

Common mix-ups

- **"Values are rules."** Rules say what you must do. Values say what you care about. Rules can be handed to you. Values have to be yours to work.
- **"If I really valued it, I'd never fail at it."** Everyone drifts from their values. The value is the direction you turn back to, not proof that you never wandered.
- **"Meaning has to be something big."** For most people, most meaning comes from small, steady things: people, care, ordinary work.
- **"Happiness is the point of life."** Feeling good matters. So does doing things that matter. A worthwhile day can be a tiring one.
- **"My values should match my partner's, or my family's."** Close people often share some values and rank others differently. That's normal, and it can be talked about.
- **"Philosophy is only for clever people."** The old questions are everyone's questions: what matters, what's fair, what's up to me. You're already asking them.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Ask, don't tell.** "What matters most to you about this?" helps more than "Here's what you should care about."

- **Notice values out loud.** "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words.
- **With children,** name the value when you see it: "You shared, even though you wanted it. That was generous." It teaches more than a lecture.
- **Don't use values as a weapon.** "I thought you valued family" is a guilt trip, not a question. Ask what family means to them instead.
- **Respect a different order.** You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

When to get more help

Feeling a bit lost or flat for a while is part of being human. But some signs mean it's worth talking to someone trained:

- Life has felt empty or pointless for more than two weeks, and things you used to enjoy don't reach you. That can be depression, which is common and treatable. A doctor or counsellor is a good first step.
- You have thoughts of not wanting to be alive. Please talk to someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

- Someone in your life is pushing you to give up what matters to you, cutting you off from friends, or making you afraid to disagree. That's about control, not values. The page When it's more than a rough patch (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) can help you think it through.

Some therapies, such as acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), work directly with values. A counsellor can help you find yours when everything feels foggy.

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Your self-discovery path (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path), step by step, and Professor Puddles (spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask), the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

Reading pages to read on the website

- Part One, Next: start with what matters: a short values step from the self-discovery part of the book.
- Library: values, what matters most (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/motivation) and self-determination theory.
- Library: why new things stop feeling new (spreadloveandacceptance.com/library/life) and comparing yourself to others.
- Stories from philosophy: What is up to us (spreadloveandacceptance.com/learn/index-in-depth), Three kinds of friendship and The circles of Hierocles.

More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · A new chapter after loss (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief)
- **Couples with different priorities:** Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · The Frequency Framework (spreadloveandacceptance.com/frequency-framework)
- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · Coming out as an adult (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out)
- **Friends and work:** Friends · At work
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens) · Growing up (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up)
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

More in Part Three

← Chapter 9: Minds that work differently (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds) · Chapter 11: Healing after hurt → (page 83) · All chapters in the contents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/contents)

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Values are directions, not finish lines.** You never "complete" kindness. You keep turning towards it.
- ✓ **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness; hurt often guards closeness.
- ✓ **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.
- ✓ **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1 · Who you are becoming
Turning values into one small goal — Know Yourself Kindly

Book 4 · Two kinds of fair
Two kinds of fair — Share the Load

Book 3 · Groups, influence and culture
Whose values a group rewards — Understanding Each Other

Book 1 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Worth that is not a score — Know Yourself Kindly

PUT IT TO USE



Your self-discovery path
Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



Part One, Next: start with what matters
A short values step from the self-discovery part of the book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values-in-depth

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03`

In: Habits and change (page 101)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Anger (page 27), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13`

In: Habits and change (page 101)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15`

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 119)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **After a talk went wrong: a step-by-step reset** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

In: Healing after hurt (page 83)

TOOL **Make a pause plan for arguments** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Anger (page 27)

TOOL **Turn a complaint into a request** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45)

TOOL **What feels like care to me: a care card** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 119)

TOOL **Where a reaction comes from** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 119)

TOOL **Upset right now? A 5-minute calm-down** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Anger (page 27), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 65), Healing after hurt (page 83), Habits and change (page 101)

TOOL **Soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

In: Anger (page 27)

TOOL **Calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 7), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 65)

TOOL **How am I right now? A mood and energy check** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page 45), Habits and change (page 101)

TOOL **Talk it through in writing** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Loss, grief and big life changes (page 65), Healing after hurt (page 83)

TOOL **Ask a question in your own words** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 119)

TOOL **Calm football game for small kind acts** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Habits and change (page 101)

TOOL **Handoff-bag checklist for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`

In: Healing after hurt (page **83**)

TOOL **10-minute team check-in** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: Stress and the nervous system (page **7**), Anger (page **27**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **45**), Habits and change (page **101**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **119**)

TOOL **Connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page **119**)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Drift
Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

If-then plan
A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

Kinship care
When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. Today's Weather calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load
The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Owner (one owner per job)
The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure
Pressure, in Today's Weather, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (usually a year or more for adults). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

Rumination

Going over the same worry or regret again and again without getting closer to an answer.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?: a load score from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Window of tolerance

The range in which you can feel strong feelings and still think and talk. Above it you are flooded or revved up; below it you shut down. A phrase from the psychiatrist Dan Siegel.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes



The 147 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online: `spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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